

After the Story: Grasshoppers in Their Sight

by Douglass Burley Johnson

A companion study to *Run the Bob Wire Home*

Back to the Section Line

Go back with me to Cimarron County, out at the far west end of the Oklahoma Panhandle, on the afternoon of April 14, 1935. It has been the prettiest Sunday in a month. Opal Strand is twelve and her brother Wendell is seven, and they are walking home along a four-strand barbed wire fence after carrying buttermilk to a widow a mile and a half down the section line. Their father, Walt, has quit church. Four years with no rain and a summer of grasshoppers took the heart out of him, and he spends Sunday mornings on the porch with his hat over his face while their mother prays for him through the bedroom wall.

You remember how it went. The birds go over first, thousands of them, flying south as low as the fence posts. The air turns cold. Then the black roller comes out of the north, a wall of dirt higher than any thunderhead, and Opal does what her mother told her to do every time she left the yard. She finds the bob wire. She ties Wendell to her wrist with the sash off her Sunday dress, puts one of Papa's old gloves on each of them, and starts home hand over hand in a dark so total she cannot see her own fingers.

Then the wire starts to spark with static, and in the blue flashes Opal sees them. Men in the field, taller than the windmill, walking toward the fence. They never touch the children. They talk. In kind voices, close as a whisper, they tell Opal the wire is going the wrong way, that she will smother out there, that her papa is this way, and to let go and come. Wendell lets go. Opal hauls him back with a barb through her glove.

And then she remembers Miss Hattie's Sunday school lesson from that very morning. The twelve spies. The giants in Canaan. The ten men who said we were like grasshoppers in our own sight. The two men who said, don't be afraid of them, the Lord is with us. Opal shouts Caleb's words into the roar, and blue fire runs ahead of them along the wire toward home, barb after barb, a lit path the tall ones will not cross.

At the corner post the wire ends, with a hundred and ten steps of bare yard between the children and the house. One of the tall ones is standing in that yard. And for the first time, it tells Opal to hold on to the wire. Then she hears her father on the porch, hollering the Twenty-third Psalm into the dark, the first prayer anybody has heard out of him in a year. Opal lets go of the wire and walks toward his voice.

Tonight's study is about giants. More than that, it is about voices.

Questions to Sit With

1. Read Numbers 13:25 through 14:9. Twelve men see the same land, the same fruit, and the same people. Ten bring back what Scripture calls a bad report, and say they looked like grasshoppers to themselves and to the giants. Caleb and Joshua tear their clothes and tell the people the Lord is with them and not to fear. What made the difference between the ten and the two? They had the same eyes. What did they have in their hearts?
2. Read Genesis 6:1-4, then 2 Peter 2:4 and Jude 6. Scripture speaks of the sons of God, the daughters of men, and the Nephilim, the mighty men of old. Christians have read these verses more than one way for two thousand years. Why do you think the Bible tells us so little about them, and so much about what God did next?
3. Read John 10:1-5 and John 10:27. Jesus says His sheep know His voice and follow Him, and they will run from the voice of a stranger. Opal heard two voices in the dark at the corner post. How did she know which one to follow? How do you?

The Teaching: Giants and the Bad Report

Start with what the tall ones did. The story is careful about this. They walk alongside and they talk, and they keep their great long arms to themselves. Every bit of the danger they carry rides in on a voice, and the voice is gentle.

That is very old work. The first lie in Scripture came the same way, in a garden, in the form of a question about what God had really said (Genesis 3:1). Jesus called the devil a liar and the father of lies (John 8:44). And Paul told the Ephesians that our fight is against rulers and authorities in the unseen world, spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places (Ephesians 6:12).

Josh McDowell and Sean McDowell, in *The Bible Handbook of Difficult Verses*, say of that verse in Ephesians: "He is speaking here of a world on a dimension that is real yet invisible to us humans." (McDowell and McDowell, *Difficult Verses from the Book of Hebrews*). That is the thin veil this whole collection is written around. The unseen world is close, close as a voice at your ear in a dust storm, and most days you cannot see it at all.

So who were the giants? Here the Bible is honest with us, and we should be honest with it.

Genesis 6 tells of the sons of God taking wives from the daughters of men, and of the Nephilim, the mighty warriors of old, who were on the earth in those days. The McDowells lay out the two main readings plainly. First, the older one: "Prior to AD 500 writers of ancient Jewish and Christian literature commonly interpreted the 'sons of God' as fallen angels." (McDowell and McDowell, *Difficult Verses from the Book of Genesis*). Then the later one: "By the fourth century the book of Enoch had long been rejected and the common view was that the 'sons of God' referred to the God-fearing descendants of Seth." (McDowell and McDowell, *Difficult Verses from the Book of Genesis*).

Some say angels are spirits and cannot father children. The McDowells answer that objection with a humble line: "Others contend that we really don't know what angels, fallen or not, can do." (McDowell and McDowell, *Difficult Verses from the Book of Genesis*). And they land where an honest reader should land: "Truth is, there is a case for both views." (McDowell and McDowell, *Difficult Verses from the Book of Genesis*).

When they come to 2 Peter 2:4, where God throws the angels who sinned into chains of darkness, they draw out the hard edge of the first view. If Peter and Jude are speaking of the Genesis 6 angels, then: "This view would leave many more fallen angels or demons who are not yet chained and are presently fighting against Christians." (McDowell and McDowell, *Difficult Verses from the Book of 1 & 2 Peter*).

Notice what the story does with all of that. It never names the tall ones. Opal never calls them Nephilim. She calls them men, then big men, then them, then that one. Whatever they were, they stood out in a black roller where no man could stand, and they wanted two children off the wire. The story leaves the label alone, the same way the Bible leaves a great deal about the giants alone.

Now come to Numbers 13, where the giants show up again.

Here is the puzzle. The McDowells say of Genesis 6: "However, it does seem that whoever the giant Nephilite warriors were, they were destroyed in the Flood." (McDowell and McDowell, Difficult Verses from the Book of Genesis). Yet in Numbers 13:33, centuries after the Flood, ten spies come back from Canaan and say they saw the Nephilim there, the sons of Anak.

Read the verse before it. Numbers 13:32 calls their account a bad report. The sons of Anak were real. Joshua and Caleb drove them out of the hill country years later (Joshua 11:21-22; Joshua 15:13-14), and they were big men; a remnant of them stayed on in Gath, the town Goliath came from (Joshua 11:22). But when the ten spies reached for the oldest, most frightening word in their people's memory and said the Nephilim had come back, they were reporting their own fear. They looked at big men and saw the end of the world. Then they turned the fear on themselves. We were like grasshoppers in our own sight, they said, and so we were in theirs.

That is how a bad report works. It starts with a true fact, giants in the land, wire running through a dark field, and it ends with a lie about you and about God. You are small. You are alone. You will smother out there. Let go and come.

Caleb and Joshua saw the same giants. They let the giants be as big as they were and argued the presence of God. The Lord is with us, they said. Do not fear them (Numbers 14:9). That is the line Opal had in her pocket from Sunday school, and it is the line she shouted into the roar.

The story pictures what happens next as blue fire running down the wire. Some of that is weather. Dust storms on the plains really did charge fence wire with static, enough to spark and knock a man down. But the story asks you to see a second thing in the first, the way Scripture often does. The fire runs ahead toward home and stays lit, and the tall ones cannot cross it. Prayer in this story works like Caleb's report. It tells the truth about who stands with you, and that truth makes a path through the dark.

Then comes the hardest turn in the story, at the corner post.

The wire runs out. The one thing Opal was told never to let go of has come to its end, and the tall one in the yard says, stay on the wire, Opal, where it's safe. For the first time, the enemy is quoting her mother. Hold on.

Here is why that matters. The tools God gives us, good habits, good rules, a fence line, a family rule repeated every time you leave the yard, are real gifts. Mama's rule saved those children for a mile and a half. But a rule pressed past the place God meant it to serve becomes its own kind of bad report. Its voice says, stay where you are, this is as far as safety goes, do not step out where you cannot see your feet. There is a time to hold the wire. And there is a time when the Shepherd's voice calls you off of it, into the open, toward Him.

What did Opal follow? Her father, hoarse, hollering a psalm about a shepherd. The Lord is my shepherd. Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for thou art with me (Psalm 23:1, 4, KJV). The sheep know His voice, Jesus said, and a stranger they will not follow (John 10:4-5).

And look at who was doing the hollering. Walt Strand, who had sat on his porch with his hat over his face for a year, who could not see the fence or the children or his own hand. All he could do was holler, he said. Ida told him he hollered the right thing. A broken man with cracked faith, praying out loud into a dark he could not see through, was the voice God used to bring his children home. The Shepherd often calls through a cracked human voice.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about the bad report. What are the giants in your land right now? Name them out loud, around the table: money, sickness, a diagnosis, a marriage, a nation coming apart, a dust storm of news. Then ask the harder question. What lie has the fear been telling you about yourself? Where have you been calling yourself a grasshopper?

Talk about the voices. The tall ones in the story were kind. They used her papa's name. Read 1 John 4:1, where John tells us to test the spirits. How can you tell the Shepherd's voice from a stranger's voice? Here is one test from the story: the stranger told Opal to let go of what God had given her, and then, when the wire ran out, told her to cling to it past where it went. The Shepherd's voice always pulls toward Him.

Talk about Walt. Is there a Walt in your house, or are you the Walt? Someone who has quit, who sits on the porch with his hat down, who prays through no wall at all? Ida did not nag him. She prayed for him at night and kept putting the gloves in Opal's pocket. Who are you praying for through the wall? And if you are the one on the porch, remember that the first prayer out of

Walt's mouth in a year was hollered, hoarse, and borrowed from a psalm he had known since boyhood. It was enough.

Talk about Opal's hands. She came home with scars across both palms, and she kept the gloves in a cigar box for the rest of her life. Faith in this story costs you. It tears your gloves to strings. What has following the Lord cost you, and what would you keep in your own cigar box to show your grandchildren?

Try this, this week. Read Numbers 13:25 through 14:9, Genesis 6:1-4, John 10:1-5, and Psalm 23 out loud, slow, with a pencil in your hand. On one side of a page write BAD REPORT and under it write the things fear has been telling you. On the other side write CALEB'S REPORT and under it write the promises of God that answer each one, with chapter and verse. Then pick one person who is out in the dark tonight, and do what Walt did. Holler for them. Pray out loud, by name, so somebody can hear it. Then step off the wire where the Lord calls you, and walk toward His voice with your hands open.

Works Cited

McDowell, Josh, and Sean McDowell. *The Bible Handbook of Difficult Verses*. Eugene, OR: Harvest House Publishers, 2013.

Psalm 23:1, 4. *The Holy Bible*, King James Version. Public domain.